authorities launched the so-called ‘Ochsenkopf’ campaign which asked (not ordered) the population to remove devices in television sets that enabled reception from the West (the construction and alignment of roof antennas ‘gave away’ those tuning into FRG TV). As there was never a legal ban on watching West German programmes, Honecker manoeuvred at periscope depth to secretly encourage groups of FDJers to remove offending TV antennas. While some kids stole aerials, others were snapped, turned eastwards, bent or had their cables severed. However, none of this vandalism seemed to do any good, and instead of creating an information monopoly, it caused resentment and led to criminal charges against several FDJ members.4

Honecker had more success giving speeches on the economy, where he worked the crowds across the GDR, telling them it was important to solve economic tasks ‘as precisely as the security measures of 13 August in Berlin were solved’.5 Indeed, by mid-1962, with the flight of citizens stalled, the discord about the Wall had become a mere side-show in Honecker’s eyes. Across the GDR, the economy was exhibiting the first signs of recovery, leading to improved living standards. There was an increase in the availability of consumer goods, with official figures showing for every 1,000 households there were 56 cars, 160 motorcycles, 122 refrigerators, 134 washing machines and 327 television sets. Deutsche Post recorded an increase of 33,300 telephone subscriptions to about 670,200 connections.6 Furthermore, production of the Trabant P60 motorcar began in Zwickau (Saxony) at the VEB Sachsenring Automobilwerke, with the promise of making the country more mobile. American journalist Arthur J. Olsen noted that people had a little more money to spend, a few more things to buy, and a new sense of individual opportunity. ‘All these are reflected in a moderate rise of public morale.’7

An additional source of hard currency was found with the establishment of ‘Intershop’, a trading organisation designed to be used by foreigners. The GDR was ready to stain its ideological purity by targeting transit travellers and visitors from ‘non-socialist economic areas’ at a Friedrichstraße station kiosk, selling cut-price cigarettes for dollars and all West European currencies, West German marks were especially welcome (GDR citizens were officially forbidden to own Western currency). Gradually, as the